

THE MCB FRAMEWORK

HOW TO FIND YOUR AIRBNB PROPERTY

Micromarket. Customer. Budget. A working checklist for first-time hosts.

Most first-time hosts start by browsing listing sites. That is the wrong starting point, because it means you are choosing a property before you have decided what business you are running. MCB reverses the order. You narrow the market, then define the guest, then set the money. By the time you open a listing site, you should be looking at ten properties, not ten thousand.

M — MICROMARKET

Stop thinking in cities

Nobody books a city. They book a location that solves something for them: near the ghats, near the beach clubs, near the office, near the temple. A property six kilometres from the demand driver is a completely different business from one that is walking distance, even though both sit in the same city and both show up in the same search results.

Same City, Different Business

City	Micromarket A	Micromarket B	Why They Differ
Goa	North Goa (Anjuna, Vagator)	South Goa (Palolem, Agonda)	Nightlife and groups vs quiet and couples. Different guest, different pricing, different season.
Varanasi	Near the ghats	6 km from ghats	Walkable to Ganga Aarti commands a premium. Distance kills it, regardless of how good the interiors are.

Micromarket Checklist

Name the demand driver. What specific thing brings people to this area — a temple, a beach, an office campus, a hospital, a wedding venue? If you cannot name it in one sentence, you have not found a micromarket yet.

Measure the distance to it. Walking distance, short auto ride, or needs a cab? This single factor moves your nightly rate more than almost anything you can do to the property itself.

Check what already exists there. How many listings are already in this micromarket? Very few can mean untapped, or it can mean nobody stays here for a reason. Find out which.

Understand the season. Every micromarket has a peak and a dead window. Know both before you commit, and know whether your dead window is two months or five.

Draw the boundary. Write down the actual area you are searching in — specific roads, landmarks, or a radius. If your search area is "the city," you have skipped this step.

C — CUSTOMER

Pick one guest. Not everyone.

This is where most first-time hosts lose money without realising it. Trying to serve every kind of guest produces a property that is acceptable to all of them and excellent for none. Average reviews follow, and

average reviews cap your pricing permanently. The guest you choose determines the property you need — bedrooms, kitchen, check-in timing, noise tolerance, parking.

Two Guests, Same City, Two Different Properties

Requirement	Family visiting Varanasi	Friends visiting Varanasi
Bedrooms	2+ separate rooms	One large shared space works
Kitchen	Essential — they will cook	Rarely used
Check-in timing	Standard hours	Late check-in matters
Noise tolerance	Needs quiet building	Needs building that tolerates noise
Location priority	Safe, calm, near temples	Near cafes, ghats, nightlife
Length of stay	2-4 nights	1-2 nights

Customer Checklist

Write one sentence describing your guest. Who they are, why they are in this city, and who they are travelling with. If the sentence uses the word "anyone," start again.

List what that guest cannot compromise on. Not what would be nice — what would make them cancel or leave a bad review. That list is your property specification.

Identify what you can safely skip. Every guest type has things they genuinely do not care about. This is where you save money without hurting reviews.

Check how long they stay. A two-night guest and a two-week guest produce completely different economics — turnover cost, cleaning frequency, and how many bookings you need to fill a month.

Confirm the guest actually exists in your micromarket. Your chosen guest and your chosen location have to match. A corporate long-stay guest in a pilgrimage micromarket is a mismatch.

B — BUDGET

Three numbers, not one

Budget is where most plans quietly break, because people budget for the property and the furniture and forget the third number entirely. The first ninety days are the hardest — you have no reviews, so you cannot charge full rate, and occupancy is low while the listing builds credibility. If you have no runway for that period, you end up dropping prices out of desperation and anchoring your listing low permanently.

The Three Numbers

Number	What It Covers	Common Mistake
1. Property cost	Monthly rent plus security deposit (usually 2-3 months), or purchase cost if buying.	Forgetting the deposit is locked up and unavailable.
2. Setup cost	Furniture, appliances, AC, kitchen, linen, decor, professional photography. Roughly Rs 2-2.5 lakh for a 2BHK.	Skipping professional photography to save Rs 8,000.
3. 90-day runway	Rent, utilities, and operating costs for the first three months while reviews build and occupancy ramps.	Not budgeting this at all. This is the one people miss.

Budget Checklist

Calculate all three numbers separately before you commit to anything. If you can only afford two of the three, you are not ready yet.

Confirm your deposit is genuinely spare capital. It is locked for the length of the lease and you cannot access it if things get tight.

Do not cut professional photography. It is a small line item that directly affects how many people click your listing at all.

Assume low occupancy for the first 90 days. Plan for it rather than hoping against it. Reviews are what unlock both occupancy and pricing.

Know your break-even occupancy. At your rent and your expected nightly rate, what percentage occupancy covers your monthly costs? If that number is above 60 percent, the deal is fragile.

Putting It Together

Run the framework in order. Micromarket narrows the map. Customer defines the property. Budget confirms whether the deal works. Each step eliminates options, which is the point — you are trying to get from an entire city down to a handful of properties worth actually visiting.

Only after all three are answered should you contact a broker. At that point you can tell them exactly what you want: the specific area, the property type, the configuration, and your rent range. Brokers respond very differently to a specific brief than to someone still exploring, and you will waste far less of everyone's time.

One more thing worth checking before any lease is signed: confirm in writing that the landlord permits short-term rental and subletting, and check the society or association rules separately. These are two different approvals and both can stop the business before it starts.

Based on research and personal experience. Please do your own research as well.

Research by @iamsatyavyas | July 2026